for a drive. Ratan was at the wheel. He pushed the gas pedal to the floor in a flash, enjoying the thrilling sound of the accelerating 90 bhp engine, ignoring Jack's caution that the car's tyres were bald. Jack was, in fact, planning to replace them the next day. The car accelerated to almost its top speed. Suddenly, a dog dashed onto the road from an alley. Car and dog lunged towards each other at a faster pace than Ratan's thrilled brain could process. Ratan did nothing except reflexively 'jerk', and that was all it took for the sports car to fishtail. The two young men realized that they were going under. Jack shouted, 'Get your head down', and both ducked instinctively as the car cartwheeled two to three times before the momentum of the vehicle dissipated, bringing it to a halt.

As the 100 was a convertible, it had nothing above the windshield. Hitting the ground, the windshield dispersed with a loud splitting sound. The windows of the side doors could not withstand the forceful scraping on the road either. The whole car 'telescoped'. Ratan and Jack were lucky to escape with their lives. Both the boys were dazed, visibly shaken and, in a state of confusion, they called the highway patrol for help. The patrol came and dragged the mangled car to one side. Looking at the startled boys, they said rather sternly: 'Next time, don't try to save a dog.' The dog did escape unhurt, incidentally.

Taking to the Skies

Flying has been an enduring passion with Ratan, and he has pursued it with childlike delight. 'Flying was my love and joy' and it entailed a 'a lot of crazy things', he said many years later. Ratan started his flying classes in Bombay when he was barely fourteen. He could not get a private licence as he was underage and had to wait until he joined Cornell to start flying again. Within a year of his joining the university, he enrolled with Chartair, owned and run by Allen W. Hayes, for flying lessons. He soon began training on a Piper J-3 Cub, an American light aircraft. He was determined to get his licence faster than the normal process. But he had to clock forty hours of solo flying, and that was not cheap in the US. He was virtually penniless by mid-month, having spent most of his pocket money on buying flying hours. The Reserve Bank of India had imposed strict conditions on the funds that could be sent outside the country, so he had to make do with only $180 that he received from home every month. It led to the